

A home in the rock

Spruce Tree House is one of hundreds of cliff alcove villages in the area known as Mesa Verde. "Mesa" is the name for the sandstone bluffs that dominate this wild region. Many of these feature the natural alcoves that the Puebloans made into homes. In the late 13th century, however, the people who lived here made the decision to move away, maybe due to a severe drought that made life difficult.

1 The flat plateau above the cliff, known as the mesa top, is where the Puebloan farmers once grew their food.

2 Sandstone makes up the sheer cliff face. Depending on the light, its color changes from pale yellow to pink-orange.

3 The village was cleverly constructed in a natural alcove in the cliff. Like everything in Puebloan life, it was created in balance with the environment.

4 A deep ravine separates the cliff that holds Spruce Tree House from the taller cliff opposite.

Spruce and juniper trees grow around the village. Juniper was, and is, used in Puebloan ceremonies.

Sandstone bluffs rise up from deep ravines in a landscape shaped millions of years ago.

Whose land?

Mesa Verde was made a national park in 1906. This was done to preserve the cultural heritage and nature of the area, but the Puebloans—the people who have the strongest connection to the land and know its history—were not consulted in the process. Today, Puebloan people are working toward having the right to manage sacred sites such as Mesa Verde.

